

# A Short Case for Boring Output

*Why the same page, over and over, beats visual variety when the goal is to be read.*

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Most document generators optimize for **visual variety** — icons, gradients, accent palettes, rounded corners, illustrated divider graphics. This one does not. It aims to produce *the same kind of page, over and over*, with as little chrome as the content will tolerate. The reference points, if any, are the [Manutius pocket editions](#), the [Penguin Rules of Composition](#), and the long shelf of technical manuals that quietly just work.

## WHY

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The point of a printed page is **to be read**.

- Every extra color is a decision the reader has to resolve.
- Every rounded corner is a style choice the reader has to *accept or ignore*.
- Every shadow is an attempt to imitate paper that paper itself does not need.

When those decisions aren't yours to make, the reader can just read. See [The Elements of Typographic Style](#) for the long version of this argument — or the much shorter version in Matthew Butterick's [Typography for Lawyers](#).

## WHAT YOU GET

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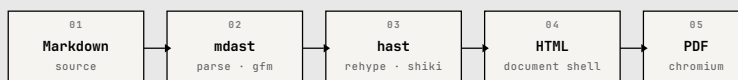
| Element | Treatment                                                  |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| H1/H3   | Archivo 500, ink, used as the on-page display heading      |
| H2      | Tracked uppercase eyebrow with a hairline rule below       |
| H4      | Archivo 500 at 14pt – sub-heading inside a section         |
| Body    | Archivo 10.5pt, 0.62em leading, italic emphasis stays sans |
| Code    | Warm surface panel, JetBrains Mono, lang/filename header   |
| Tables  | Tracked uppercase header, hairline rule, no verticals      |
| Links   | Ink, underlined                                            |

| Element  | Treatment                                                 |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Callouts | Note, tip, warning, danger – left rule + 500-weight label |
| Header   | Section · Title · Date, tracked sans uppercase, hairline  |
| Footer   | Folio in italic Instrument Serif, centered                |

## HOW

1. Extract frontmatter with `gray-matter`.
2. Parse Markdown to an mdast tree ( `remark-parse` + `remark-gfm` + `remark-directive` + `remark-math` + `remark-definition-list` ), normalising Pandoc-dialect surface forms in a pre-parse pass.
3. Walk the tree and emit Typst source — admonitions become `#callout` blocks, code fences carry through filename + lang attrs, math maps to native Typst symbols.
4. Spawn `typst compile` against the bundled fonts, with `--ignore-system-fonts` so the output is identical on every machine.

Nothing in that list is novel. The novelty, if any, is in what's left out.



*Fig. 1* The five stages the pipeline passes through, from Markdown source to printed PDF.

## CODE, FOR FLAVOR

```

const { content, frontmatter } = extractFrontmatter(raw);
const resolved = resolveOptions({ cli, frontmatter, project });
const tree = parseMarkdownToMdast(content);
const typst = generateTypst(tree, { sourceDir:
dirname(inputPath) });
await compileTypst(typst, { outputPath, fontPath: "assets/
fonts" });

```

One call per stage. No theme registry, no plugin API — if a second output format ever arrives, we can add one then.

## CALLOUTS

Four kinds, one source format — a Pandoc fenced div, named for the intent:

```

:::note , :::tip , :::warning , :::danger .

```

### NOTE

Useful context that isn't load-bearing. A quiet aside the reader can take or leave.

**TIP**

A practical hint — non-essential, but the document is better if the reader picks it up in passing.

**WARNING**

Something the reader must not miss. The hairline frame and the tracked label carry the signal without resorting to color.

**DANGER**

The single inversion in the system — page-colored text on ink. Reserved for the warning the reader cannot afford to skim.

**A NOTE ON CHECKLISTS**

- ☒ Five ~~accent palettes~~.
- ☒ Grayscale only — no accent color.
- ☒ Header and footer in the same typographic voice.
- ☒ Cover page with suppressed running header on page 1.
- ☐ Table of contents with real page numbers (next).

The strikethrough, task list, and nested list all render from a single Markdown source — no special syntax, no escape hatches.

**CLOSING**

*Design is a plan for arranging elements in such a way as best to accomplish a particular purpose.*

— Charles Eames, who knew a thing or two about chairs.

If a boring page is readable, and a readable page gets read, the boring page has out-performed the interesting one. That is the whole case.